meetings of the French and the British Prime Ministers with President Rouhani in September 2014.

The whole episode is disturbing. The international community seems to have reconciled itself to the fact that an influential country such as Iran is advocating and preparing the destruction of Israel. How can this be? Why is the clear Iranian statement of intent not taken seriously? The answers to these questions are in my opinion related to the fact that the crucial question of WHY—why does the Iranian leadership want Israel to disappear?—is rarely raised and even more rarely answered. It is, however, a very good question.

Between 1948 and 1979, Israel and Iran co-operated successfully, not only on security issues but also in the fields of agriculture, hydraulic engineering, health, and industry. The two nations had never had any territorial disputes or any kind of refugee problem. Indeed, throughout history, Iranians have viewed the Arabs as their adversaries while Iranian Jews and non-Jews have lived together for more than 2,500 years. That might be why the Iranian population is even today the least antisemitic one in the Middle East, as a recent survey shows.[4]

In 1979 however, "Iran went from being an important strategic partner of Israel. . .to becoming its most dangerous and implacable enemy," observed Robert Wistrich. "With no other country were Iran's relations overturned so speedily and drastically."[5] The question again is: why? There is a convincing answer, although it is rarely discussed: because of the antisemitism of Iran's Islamist leadership.

Israel, the Jews and Iran

Ruhollah Khomeini, who led Iran's revolution in 1979, was the first Iranian to speak about Jewish world domination and discover the mobilizing power of Jew-hatred. His antisemitic campaigning started in the 1960s and was characterized by three features. First, it was directed not against Zionists, but against Jews.

"I know that you do not want Iran to be under the boot of the Jews," he shouted out to his supporters in April 1963.[6] In the same year, he called the Shah a Jew in disguise and accused him of taking orders from Israel. The response was positive, tremendously so. From then on, hatred of Jews has remained a central component of Iranian Islamist ideology.

"The Jews. . .wish to establish Jewish domination throughout the world," Khomeini wrote in 1970 in his main work, *Islamic Government*. "Since they are a cunning and resourceful group of people, I fear that. . .they may one day achieve their goal."[7] In September 1977, he declared: "The Jews have

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